

Photographs courtesy DRDO



# TRIMMING THE FAT

The Defence Ministry begins belated reforms to fix the problems within the country's premier defence research organisation, but will it now deliver on time?

By Sandeep Unnithan

From his spacious fifth floor office in the sandstone-fronted headquarters of the Defence Research Development Organisation (DRDO), its chief Dr Vijay Kumar Saraswat can see both the South Block and the Sena Bhavan. One is the seat of the political executive and the other is occupied by his sole customer, the armed forces. Now, he objectively regards his new mandate

from the Government to transform his organisation. "It's not a censure, it is re-engineering," the fast-talking missile scientist explains. It is a challenge that could make his last project, shooting down incoming enemy ballistic missiles on the fringes of space, seem like a child's play.

The heart of the matter is this: India is heavily import-dependent. Over 70 per cent of the requirements for its armed forces come from foreign arms firms. Over the next decade, the armed

forces will import weapons and equipment worth an estimated \$100 billion (Rs 5 lakh crore) and half of this or nearly \$50 billion (Rs 2.5 lakh crore)—almost two entire Indian defence budgets—will be spent by the IAF to buy heavy lift aircraft and multi-role combat jets.

This import dependence comes despite having one of the world's largest government-run military-industrial complexes: 40 ordnance factories and eight defence public sector units and the DRDO on which the Government spends over Rs 8,000 crore annually. The reason: a huge institutional gap between the DRDO, services and production agencies who make up the troika of designer, manufacturer and user.